

7.c) The concept of cultural relativism and the ensuing debates surrounding it have sparked discussions within Anthropology. Comment. (15 marks)

As per Robert Redfield, cultural relativism refers to objectively analysing a society in the context of that society's problems and opportunities. It is hallmark of Anthropology.

Origin of concept

- Alvin Locke coined the term in 1924
- In response to Classical evolutionists' ethnocentric approach; Yung Boas gave the concept of historical particularism saying that "each culture is meaningful in its own context"
- The idea was further popularised by Culture Personality and Post Modernists

Benefits of Cultural Relativism

- Tolerance approach → for better understanding
e.g. Dr. Majumdar understood cultural reasons behind group marriage of Khasas seen

- with suspicion all around the world
- Born myths e.g. Racism, labelled savage nature of tribes
- Applied and Action Anthropology
 - e.g. Rural perspectives enrich Rapid Rural Appraisal
 - e.g. Community Development Program by SC Dube
- Ensuring world peace by removing xenophobia
 - e.g. Jews' violence against Jews in WWII

However, cultural relativism has raised following fears →

Critics

- 1 → Elizabeth Zechenter - It leads to violation of human rights in the name of cultural practice
 - e.g. Genital mutilation in Akan of Ghana, Bodhras muslims
- 2 → Censures - Social Approval should not precede moral approval
 - e.g. Sati, child marriage - Violate women's dignity and right to life
- 3 → Mengam Namezie - It is used as excuse to justify practices like → ordeals among

Males → life threatening practice of licking hot iron axe ; honor killing in caste system.

→ Herskovitz - "All Judgements are based on past experience" → raised the debate that being truly objective and unbiased not possible with human psyche

However - Paul Hirsch has correctly said that - understanding the cultures with Culture Relativism and further convincing the tribes using the same understanding is made possible by his approach

Contemporary Relevance And all these debates there have been times when anthropologists used the understanding to solve vaccine hesitancy, convince tribals for very important strategic directions of forest.

In correct way → It can be used to solve problems as complex as Left wing Extremism